

KEY ASSUMPTIONS CHECK

List and review the key working assumptions on which fundamental judgments rest.

WHEN TO USE

A Key Assumptions Check is most useful at the beginning of an analytic project. An individual analyst or a team can spend an hour or two articulating and reviewing the key assumptions. Rechecking assumptions also can be valuable at any time prior to finalizing judgments, to insure that the assessment does not rest on flawed premises. Identifying hidden assumptions can be one of the most difficult challenges an analyst faces, as they are ideas held—often unconsciously—to be true and, therefore, are seldom examined and almost never challenged.

A key assumption is any hypothesis that analysts have accepted to be true and which forms the basis of the assessment. For example, military analysis may focus exclusively on analyzing key technical and military variables (sometimes called factors) of a military force and “assume” that these forces will be operated in a particular environment (desert, open plains, arctic conditions, etc.). Postulating other conditions or assumptions, however, could dramatically impact the assessment. Historically, US analysis of Soviet-Warsaw Pact operations against NATO had to “assume” a level of non-Soviet Warsaw Pact reliability (e.g., would these forces actually fight?). In this case, there was high uncertainty and depending on what level of reliability one assumed, the analyst could arrive at very different

conclusions about a potential Soviet offensive operation. Or when economists assess the prospects for foreign economic reforms, they may consciously, or not, assume a degree of political stability in those countries or the region that may or may not exist in the future. Likewise, political analysts reviewing a developing country’s domestic stability might unconsciously assume stable oil prices, when this key determinant of economic performance and underlying social peace might fluctuate. All of these examples highlight the fact that analysts often rely on stated and unstated assumptions to conduct their analysis. The goal is not to undermine or abandon key assumptions; rather, it is to make them explicit and identify what information or developments would demand rethinking them.

VALUE ADDED

Explicitly identifying working assumptions during an analytic project helps:

- Explain the logic of the analytic argument and expose faulty logic.
- Understand the key factors that shape an issue.
- Stimulate thinking about an issue.
- Uncover hidden relationships and links between key factors.
- Identify developments that would cause you to abandon an assumption.
- Prepare analysts for changed circumstances that could surprise them.